METHODOLOGY

HOW THE UNIVERSITIES WERE RANKED

With more than 1,000 universities, including 522 general, 177 technical, 66 medical and 23 law, the India Today Group's annual ranking of Best Universities has a special place in the country's academic calendar. It not only makes critical career decision easier for aspirants based on rich information and data but also provides an overview of the state of university education to other stakeholders such as recruiters, parents, alumni, policy-makers and people at large.

INDIA TODAY's knowledge partner, Marketing and Development Research Associates (MDRA), a reputed research agency, followed a rigorous methodology while conducting this survey between January 2022 and July 2022. For objective ranking, MDRA carefully fine-tuned 120+ attributes to provide a comprehensive and balanced comparison of universities. These performance indicators were clubbed into five broad parameters—'Reputation & Governance', 'Academic & Research Excellence', 'Infrastructure & Living Experience', 'Personality & Leadership Development' and 'Career Progression & Placement'. In addition, how the universities adapted to the Covid situation was also assessed. The ranking is based on current-year data provided by the universities.

A list of 750-plus qualifying universities fulfilling the criteria was prepared. Post-graduate courses under four streams—general, medical, technical and law—were considered for evaluation. Only universities offering full-time, in-classroom courses and having produced a minimum of three pass-out batches by the end of 2020 qualified for the rankings.

Experts with rich experience in their fields were consulted to frame the parameters and sub-parameters for the respective categories of universities. Indicators were meticulously determined, and their relative weights finalised.

A comprehensive objective questionnaire was sent to qualifying universities and also uploaded on the respective websites of MDRA and INDIA TODAY. As many as 160 universities provided their data along with voluminous supporting documents within the stipulated deadline but only 158 were ranked, as two universities could not meet the eligibility criteria.

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After receiving the objective data from universities, a detailed scrutiny of the supporting documents was undertaken. Data was verified by every possible means. An objective score was given to each university under the five indicators. While calculating the objective score, it was ensured that aggregate data alone were not used. Hence, data were normalised.

A perceptual survey was carried out among 329 well-informed respondents (38 chancellors/ vice-chancellors, 75 directors/ deans/ registrars), 216 senior faculty (professors and heads of departments) across 30 cities divided into the following four zones:

- **North: Delhi-NCR, Lucknow, Jaipur and Chandigarh**
- **West: Mumbai, Pune, Ahmedabad and Indore**
- **South: Chennai, Bengaluru, Hyderabad and Coimbatore**
- **East: Kolkata, Bhubaneswar, Guwahati and Patna**

National and zonal rankings were taken from them in their respective fields of experience and given 75 per cent and 25 per cent weightage respectively. They also rated the universities on a 10-point rating scale on each of the five key parameters. The total scores arrived at from the objective and perceptual surveys were added in the ratio of 50:50 to determine the total combined score.

The MDRA core team, led by executive director Abhishek Agrawal, included project director Abnish Jha, assistant research manager Vaibhav Gupta, research executive Aditya Srivastava and executive-EDP Manveer Singh. ■